

The Aesthetics of Harm: Reader Complicity in Nabokov's *Lolita*

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For me a work of fiction exists only insofar as it affords me what I shall bluntly call aesthetic bliss, that is a sense of being somehow, somewhere, connected with other states of being where art (curiosity, tenderness, kindness, ecstasy) is the norm.

Vladimir Nabokov, *On a Book Entitled Lolita*

“Aesthetic bliss,” as a character named Vladimir Nabokov claims above, is the ultimate aim of fiction: an ecstasy born not just of language, but of the reader’s willing surrender to narrative seduction. Yet this bliss becomes ethically fraught when the narrative voice itself is morally compromised. For a novel like *Lolita*, Humbert Humbert’s famously artful narration is inseparable from his horrific crimes, a tension that has fueled critics’ vision of *Lolita* as a potentially dangerous novel. Upon its reception, the novel was banned by governments, and remains an integral part in debates about art, censorship, and violence.

Here it is at last, Vladimir Nabokov's Lolita (Putnam, \$5.00)—first issued in 1955 by an unorthodox Paris press after being rejected by a string of American publishers; banned by the French government, presumably out of solicitude for immature English-speaking readers (the ban was later quashed by the French High Court); pronounced unobjectionable by that blue-nosed body, the U. S. Customs office.

Charles J. Rolo, Lolita, by Vladimir Nabokov (1958)

However, in order to truly reckon with *Lolita*, we must begin by loosening the grip of Humbert's narratorial voice and examining our role as the reader with a critical eye. What does it mean to be drawn into the perspective of a narrator who manipulates language to obscure and aestheticize harm? And how does Humbert's control over the text shape our ethical engagement with guilt, desire, and suffering? Before answering these questions directly in *Lolita*, it is helpful to turn to Edgar Allan Poe, not only because he is explicitly invoked in *Lolita*, but also because his works offer a useful lens through which to examine the engine of narrative manipulation. Poe's poem "Annabel Lee" is woven directly into the origins of Humbert Humbert's desire for nymphets, as he attributes his obsession to an unresolved childhood love with Annabel Leigh, a clear reference to Poe's poem: "in point of fact, there might have been no Lolita at all had I not loved, one summer, a certain initial girl-child. In a pryncedom by the sea" (Nabokov, 9).

It was many and many a year ago,

In a kingdom by the sea,

That a maiden there lived whom you may know

By the name of Annabel Lee;

And this maiden she lived with no other thought

Than to love and be loved by me.

I was a child and she was a child,

In this kingdom by the sea,

But we loved with a love that was more than love—

I and my Annabel Lee—

With a love that the wingèd seraphs of Heaven

Coveted her and me.

And this was the reason that, long ago,

In this kingdom by the sea,

A wind blew out of a cloud, chilling

My beautiful Annabel Lee;

So that her highborn kinsmen came

And bore her away from me,

To shut her up in a sepulchre

In this kingdom by the sea.

The angels, not half so happy in Heaven,

Went envying her and me—

Yes!—that was the reason (as all men know,

In this kingdom by the sea)

That the wind came out of the cloud by night,

Chilling and killing my Annabel Lee.

But our love it was stronger by far than the love

Of those who were older than we—

Of many far wiser than we—

And neither the angels in Heaven above

Nor the demons down under the sea

Can ever dissever my soul from the soul

Of the beautiful Annabel Lee;

For the moon never beams, without bringing me dreams

Of the beautiful Annabel Lee;

And the stars never rise, but I feel the bright eyes

Of the beautiful Annabel Lee;

*And so, all the night-tide, I lie down by the side
Of my darling—my darling—my life and my bride,
In her sepulchre there by the sea—
In her tomb by the sounding sea.*

Edgar Allan Poe, Annabel Lee

This initial reference invites the reader to see Humbert's desire for nymphets with the romantic tragedy of "Annabel Lee" in mind, invoking emotions of loss and longing. Yet, this framing is suspicious, and understanding this framework, as well as the other molding tactics of Humbert, requires looking beyond "Annabel Lee" to another of Poe's works, "Berenice."

While "Annabel Lee" allows Humbert and the reader to contextualize his desire, "Berenice" is instructive in terms of narrative structure and strategy. Poe creates the narrator Egaeus, whose obsessive and self-serving voice distorts the reality of his crimes towards Berenice and mirrors the narrative scheme of Humbert. A close analysis of "Berenice" allows us to see an exaggerated form of the techniques that Humbert subtly utilizes to influence and control the reader.

Narrative Delay and Emotional Processing

The primary point of examinations must first be the narrators, whose perspectives govern not only the plot but also the reader's access to truth, harm, and accountability. It is important to note that there is no such thing as a reliable narrator, especially in fiction told in the first-person. Although the primary job of the narrator in fiction is to tell a story, their immediate secondary purpose is to insist upon their inevitably subjective version of the story. As Judith Butler notes in *Senses of the Subject*, there exists an inevitable gap between experience and narration: "If I say

that I am already affected before I can say ‘I,’ I am speaking much later than the process I seek to describe” (Butler, 2). This temporal and psychological distance means that complete objectivity in narration is impossible, as emotional processes inevitably alter perception between story and discourse. This unavoidable subjectivity makes every narrator not so much a transparent glass but rather a constructed lens, colored by memory, emotion, and desire, through which the reader engages with the narrative.

In texts such as Poe’s *Berenice* and Nabokov’s *Lolita*, this lens becomes more than a narrative convention to a site of distortion that actively shapes the reader’s relationship to violence and guilt. While Egaeus writes as though the events of *Berenice* unfold in front of him, the readers of *Lolita* are made aware of the fact that Humbert is narrating past events by the occasional address to the “ladies and gentlemen of the jury” (or something of the sort). Still, both narratives are told in the past tense, and although the timeline may be unclear, we can safely presume that these narrations occurred at least some time after the events themselves unfolded. This distinction between the narration and the actual events is crucial because “narrative authority does not require being at the scene. It requires only that one is able to reconstruct the scene from a position of nonpresence in a believable way or that one’s unbelievable narration is compelling for its own reasons” (Butler, 4). The important qualification of narration is the verb “reconstruct.” Both Humbert and Egaeus are “reconstructing” their narratives, not simply recounting them like historical nonfiction writing would. Thus, their narrations do not consist only of their account of the events, but also include their own mediation on these events. As the readers, this invokes questions not of *what* happened, but *why* these narrators choose to frame the stories in the way they do. For both of these narratives, their respective narrators are concerned

with imposing justification and rationale to their own violent and ethically charged actions that are encased within the story.

Further, it is important to note that both of these narrators attempt to smother the emotional processes of Berenice and Dolores Haze respectively. In genres like memoirs, it is instinctively clear to readers that the narrator is writing from a distinctively past tense about past events. This is not nearly as readily recognized in works of fiction, although it is equally important to be cognizant of this, especially when the narrator so forcefully imposes upon the reader his own agenda. To fully understand the time in which a narrative takes place, we refer back to Butler in her claim that “the narrative dimension [is] [...] inevitably belated, especially when the task is to discern how the subject is initially animated by what affects it and how these transitive processes are reiterated in the animated life that follows” (Butler, 4). The time between the delayed reiteration and the actual narration occurs is marked by the “threshold of susceptibility and transfer” that occurs by both the author and the narrator (Butler, 3).

Egaeus’s narration in *Berenice* is marked by a temporal instability that mirrors the very susceptibility Butler identifies. Egaeus speaks not from the immediacy of action but from a retrospective vantage that blurs the boundary between hallucination and memory. Like Butler’s example of the narrator in *David Copperfield*, Egaeus seemingly attempts to reconstruct an experience he was not a full agent in. He does not recount the event of mutilating Berenice as a volitional act, but as a kind of amnesic state into which he was absorbed and from which he reemerges horrified. This narrative delay, which Butler draws on Freud’s idea of *nachträglichkeit*, “is an inevitable feature of inquiries [...], inflecting the narration with the historical perspective of the present” (Butler, 3). It is the concept of *nachträglichkeit* that allows Egaeus to defer and diffuse responsibility through the retroactive structuring of experience. His

fragmented narration, shown by the dissociation between past events and present narration, creates a space where guilt is displaced onto the instability of the self rather than assumed as ethical accountability. Egaeus shows the “narrative fashion that marks the paradoxical condition of trying to relate something about [his] formation that is prior to [his] own narrative capacity and that, in fact, brings that narrative capacity about” (Butler, 2). His narration thus performs the very problem of belated subjectivity. Egaeus displaces the readers into his structural fog of madness, exploiting the gap between affect and articulation to obscure his violence.

Whether Egaeus’s lapse in consciousness and narration is due to monomania does not alter the fact that Berenice is the character who has the most obvious claim to trauma following the violence acted upon her. Egaeus’s use of unitary language, defined by Mikhail M. Bakhtin as constituting “the theoretical expression of the historical processes of linguistic unification and centralization” (Hale, 489), gives him complete power over the narrative. His choice not to disclose his actions during which he mutilated Berenice effectively takes away any inclusion of Berenice as a character and victim in the narrative. By omitting the very moment of violence, he denies Berenice any narrative agency during the attack. She instead becomes merely a reference rather than a character with a subjective interiority. This further suppresses Berenice, as her trauma is rendered invisible, hidden under Egaeus’s fragmented recollection. The narrative thus becomes a closed loop centered entirely on Egaeus’s experience, where Berenice exists only as an object of obsession.

Lolita, on the other hand, gives Dolores Haze a voice in Humbert’s narration, but Humbert simultaneously pushes his own agenda onto her. Operating in the dialogic environment of a novel, Humbert’s environment is entirely different from Egaeus’s monologic story. Bakhtin refers to the term “dialogism” as the interaction between voices rather than from a single

authoritative source, which we use to describe *Lolita*. Though centered mainly around Humbert's narration, it also contains dialogue from other characters. This environment, however, allows the reader to become subtly manipulated by the primary contrast between Humbert's refined voice and Haze's adolescent, slang-heavy speech. This contrast is exemplified in Humbert and Haze's conversation in the car after camp Q:

"How was the hike? Did you have a marvelous time at the camp?"

"Uh-huh."

"Sorry to leave?"

"Un-un."

"Talk, Lo – don't grunt. Tell me something."

...

"When did you fall for my mummy?"

"Some day, Lo, you will understand many emotions and situations, such as for example the harmony, the beauty of spiritual relationship."

"Bah!" said the cynical nymphet."

Nabokov, 112

Here, Haze talks in a speech indicative of her teenage years, which Humbert admonishes her for, reinforcing the power dynamic between the two characters. Haze's flat "uh-huh" and "un-un" are juxtaposed with Humbert's description of "the beauty of spiritual relationship," which is immediately undercut by Haze's "Bah!." When the pair arrive at the hotel, Haze's excited exclamation, "Wow! Looks swank," is immediately reframed as "my vulgar darling" (Nabokov, 117). Even though the reader hears Haze's voice, the dialogue we hear is constantly subjected to

Humbert's judgement and manipulation. Soon after Humbert and Haze begin their road trip around the country, Humbert mentions the way he adopted her speech:

"In former times, when I was still your dream male [the reader will notice what pains I took to speak Lo's tongue], you swooned to records of the number one throb-and-sob idol of your coevals [Lo: "Of my what? Speak English"]."

Nabokov, 149

The "pains [Humbert] [takes] to speak Lo's tongue" is not out of empathy or compassion, but rather is a demonstration of intellectual inferiority of Haze and thus the superiority of Humbert, which is furthered by the inclusion of her comment to "speak English." Even in a formally dialogic environment, Humbert's centripetal narration smothers Haze's subjectivity. He uses the inclusion of her voice only to reshape and silence her, thereby reinforcing his authority over her and the narrative.

The ethical danger, then, lies in how both *Berenice* and *Lolita* offer the reader no stable narrative authority from which to resist the narrator's manipulations. Just as Egaeus's fragmented consciousness becomes a refuge from moral clarity, the reader, too, is suspended in a liminal space where aesthetic concerns threaten to eclipse ethical judgment. In this state, how does one combat the subtle, often subconscious manipulation embedded in texts like *Lolita* or *Berenice*? The answer begins with acknowledging the ethical responsibility the novel places on its reader.

As Judith Butler writes, "[any reader is] not only already in the hands of someone else before [they] start to work with [their] own hands, but [they are] also, as it were, in the 'hands' of institutions, discourses, environments, including technologies and life processes, handled by an

organic and inorganic object field that exceeds the human” (Butler, 7). The reader of *Lolita* is not only in Humbert’s and Nabokov’s hands, but also subject to the broader cultural frameworks such as legal or patriarchal ones that shape how narratives of abuse, desire, and power like *Berenice* or *Lolita* are told and received. Whether we approach such texts through the lenses of feminism, criminality, or aesthetics, the reader’s interpretive agency is always already mediated by structures that exceed individual judgment.

Monoglossic and Heteroglossic Environments

Both Egaeus and Humbert choose the framework of intellectual superiority to attempt to mask their crimes, using language not only as a vessel for the narrative, but also as a tool for dominance. For Egaeus, he puts up a facade of scholarly detachment that distances himself from the moral horror of his actions. He is constantly situated in the library, surrounding himself with books and intellectual abstractions that align his character with a tradition of academia. His reference to “Tertullian “de Carne Christi,” in which the paradoxical sentence “Mortuus est Dei filius; credibile est quia ineptum est: et sepultus resurrexit; certum est quia impossibile est” (The Son of God died; it is believable because it is absurd; and he was buried and resurrected; it is certain because it is impossible) occupied [his] undivided time, for many weeks of laborious fruitless investigation,” show his absorption of arcane theories, which allows him to suspend rationality and willfully retreat into an intellectual enclave.

He plays to the ethos of this paradox, aestheticizing and rationalizing madness as an intellectual pursuit. He further uses mythical imagery to allude to Berenice, idealizing her as a “sylph amid the shrubberies of Arnheim,” and “Naiad among its fountains.” By invoking imagery of spirits from Romantic and Greek mythology, Egaeus objectifies Berenice into a

symbol rather than a subject. His monologic voice, steeped in archaic diction and elevated rhetoric, operates as a centripetal force in Bakhtin's terms, which push language toward unity and suppress any heteroglossic intrusion that might disrupt his authority. In Bakhtin's words, monologism "makes its real presence felt as a force for [...] imposing specific limits to [heteroglossia], guaranteeing a certain maximum of mutual understanding and crystallizing into a real, although still relative, unity" (Hale, 489). This worldview is one where a single consciousness reigns supreme, excluding other voices and moral frameworks. The limits imposed by monologism are reflected by the erasure of Berenice's subjectivity by Egaeus, as he never grants her speech or interiority. This absence of heteroglossia, paired with his creation of himself as an intellectually detached scholar, allows him to aestheticize his obsession with Berenice's teeth while imposing a low upper bound on any moral responsibility for his mutilation of her body.

Egaeus goes so far as to acknowledge the fact that he has had no attraction to Berenice herself:

During the brightest days of her unparalleled beauty, most surely I had never loved her. In the strange anomaly of my existence, feelings with me, had never been of the heart, and my passions always were of the mind. Through the gray of the early morning – among the trellised shadows of the forest at noonday – and in the silence of my library at night, she had flitted by my eyes, and I had seen her – not as the living and breathing Berenice, but as the Berenice of a dream – not as a being of the earth, earthy, but as the abstraction of such a being – not as a thing to admire, but to analyze – not as an object of love, but as the theme of the most abstruse although desultory speculation.

Poe, 101

This confession fully crystallizes Egaeus's dispassionate objectification of Berenice. He again goes back to his crafted image as a scholar with his claim that "[his] passions always were of the mind," thus putting Berenice on a pedestal for scientific and analytic inquiry rather than a person to love. To Egaeus, Berenice is not a "being of the earth," but rather "the abstraction of such a being – not as a thing to admire, but to analyze." She is a victim of Egaeus's monologic centripetal force, which "impos[es] specific limits to [heteroglossia]" by collapsing Berenice's voice into the powerful, singular authority of Egaeus's scholarly narration, thus stripping her of her own humanity (Hale, 489).

Humbert similarly delineates his own superior intellect by writing in an ornate and cosmopolitan manner, but he does so in a more heteroglossic environment. His speech, lyrical and full of scholarly references, attempts to assert a linguistic elitism that overwhelms the reader's critical faculties. Humbert introduces himself through markers of academic success and European refinement, positioning himself as a cultured observer rather than a criminal. His coining of the term "nymphet" is marked by a tone of scholarly neutrality, which lends itself to legitimize his pedophilia. He introduces the following idea:

Between the age limits of nine and fourteen there occur maidens who, to certain bewitched travelers, twice or many times older than they, reveal their true nature which is not human, but nymph (that is, demoniac); and these chosen creatures I proposed to designate as "nymphets." [...] I would have the reader see "nine" and "fourteen: as the boundaries – the mirrory beaches and rosy rocks – of an enchanted island haunted by those nymphets of mine and surrounded by a vast, misty sea. [...] Good looks [are not] any criterion; and vulgarity, or at least what a given community terms so, does not necessarily impair certain mysterious characteristics, the fey grace, the elusive, shifty, soul-shattering, insidious charm that separates the nymphet.

By describing nymphets as though he was classifying a newly discovered species, identifiable by “the slightly feline outline of a cheekbone, the slenderness of a downy limb, and other indices” (Nabokov, 17), he uses his academic language as evidence for his detachment and thus aestheticizes his desire as an academic pursuit, similar to Egaeus. He further leans into his role as an intellectual observer as he delineates the “Lilith he longed for”:

The bud-stage of breast development appears early (10.7 years) in the sequence of somatic changes accompanying pubescence. And the next maturational item available is the first appearance of pigmented pubic hair (11.2 years).

Nabokov, 20

In this seemingly objective description, the nymphet almost seems to be a separate species altogether, neither fully girl nor nymph. This, of course, is exactly Humbert’s objective. As he classifies himself and other pedophiles, or, “[those] who are in the know, [the] lone voyagers, [the] nympholepts” (Nabokov, 16), as victims, Dolores Haze (and the other nymphets) becomes “the little deadly demon among the wholesome children” (Nabokov, 17). His language, which casts him as a dispassionate scholar merely observing a phenomenon, serves as a manipulative rationalization that aestheticizes his obsession, deflects moral accountability, and coaxes the reader into complicity through its intellectual allure.

Although *Lolita* is indeed set in a heteroglossic environment, Humbert’s grasp on the reader reminds us that he is still very much in control of the narrative. To that end, Humbert Humbert places himself and the reader in a legal framework, structuring his story in a manner that seems to indicate that he is on trial and is speaking to “the jury.” By doing so, he indicates

his awareness of the time that has passed between the events of the story and reminds the reader about this passing of time. However, by alluding to a hypothetical courtroom where the reader is a critical part of the jury, Humbert also invokes the laws of the courtroom in his narrative as well. More specifically, he implies that in his narrative, he is following the law against perjury. By the time Humbert narrates his 'testimony,' Dolores Haze is dead; so is her mother, who we can assume came closest to revealing Humbert's true intentions. There is no other witness or evidence that can testify against Humbert Humbert's claims. By creating the impression that his narrative is in the environment of legal proceedings, Humbert further pushes towards the reader the objectivity of his narration.

Yet, in both narratives, the narrators use a sinister tactic in attempts to relieve themselves of culpability in the reader's view. As Egaeus begins to regain consciousness after his violent ravaging of Berenice, he finds his hands "indented with the impress of human nails," presumably Berenice's, as she struggled to break free from his attack. However, as Egaeus's mind fractures under the weight of his obsession and his crime, the observation of Berenice's nails contort the narrative to frame Egaeus as the victim, eclipsing the fragility of Berenice, whose body he violated and whose voice he never granted. Humbert Humbert does something similar. When Humbert encounters a pregnant Dolores Haze, his cultivated façade momentarily falters not out of guilt, but from the realization that he no longer holds power over her. Yet in a surprising reversal, it is she who apologizes for refusing to return to him, a moment that fully inverts the dynamic between victim and aggressor. In both narratives, the boundary between perpetrator and victim seems to be unambiguous, but the narrators deliberately obscure this line through their monologic control of the narrative. This manipulation becomes an ethical transgression that manipulates power and perception, implicating the reader in the narrator's violence and desire.

Triangular Desire and its Manipulation

Rene Girard's concept of triangular desire offers a useful framework for examining both the narrators' manipulations and the reader's unwitting involvement in them. In *Deceit, Desire, and the Novel*, Girard defines the term "triangular desire" as an imitative desire that requires three components: the object of desire, the subject who desires it, and a third figure, the "mediator," whom the subject imitates. This last figure, the mediator, is not necessarily a singular person. When applied to "Berenice" and *Lolita*, this framework casts Egaeus and Humbert Humbert as the desiring subjects. Yet the identities of both the desired object and the mediator are far from fixed, revealing deeper layers of narrative and ethical complexity.

In exploring the complex relationship between the subject who desires and the mediator whom the subject imitates, Girard makes a distinction about two different mediators:

"We shall speak of *external mediation* when the distance is sufficient to eliminate any contact between the two spheres of possibilities of which the mediator and the subject occupy the respective centers. We shall speak of *internal mediation* when this same distance is sufficiently reduced to allow these two spheres to penetrate each other more or less profoundly."

(Hale, 299)

Notably, these two types of mediation often align with how socially acceptable the desire appears. As Girard puts it, "the hero of external mediation proclaims aloud the true nature of his desire. He worships his model openly and declares himself his disciple" (Hale, 299). The sufficient distance between the mediator and the subject in external mediation that allows the subject to be vocal about his desire is a direct result of the fact that this specific desire follows

social convention. On the other hand, “the hero of internal mediation, far from boasting of his efforts to imitate, carefully hides them” (Hale, 299). This obscuration of desire in internal mediation is largely due to society’s disapproval of said desire. To illustrate this, let us turn to Humbert and Lolita.

When we take Lolita’s sexuality to be the object of Humbert’s desire, we see an example of internal mediation, where the mediator is the forbidden ideal of adolescent innocence. Humbert’s desire is found in the secrecy of the various hotel rooms the pair travel through. The “hiding” of this desire is shown by Humbert’s consistent attempts at mitigating the raping of Dolores Haze, the manifestation of his desire. When he first rapes her, Humbert does not mention any reference to rape or intercourse, going so far as to put the word sex in quotation marks. Instead, he begins by stating “something very strange: it was she who seduced [him]” (Nabokov, 132).

Suffice it to say that not a trace of modesty did I perceive in this beautiful hardly formed young girl whom modern co-education, juvenile mores, the campfire racket and so forth had utterly and hopelessly depraved. She saw the stark merely as part of a youngster’s furtive world, unknown to adults. What adults did for purposes of procreation was no business of hers. [...] In my strange predicament, I feigned supreme stupidity and had her have her way – at least while I could still bear it. But really, these are irrelevant matters; I am not concerned with so-called “sex” at all. Anybody can imagine those elements of animality. A greater endeavor lures me on: to fix once for all the perilous magic of nymphets.

Nabokov, 133-134

This is Humbert’s way of concealing the true nature of his actions. In describing Haze as the primary actor during this encounter and situating himself as a passive pawn (“I feigned supreme stupidity and had her have her way”), Humbert shrugs off responsibility in what can only be

described as a sexual encounter with a minor. He tries to hide behind the explanation that Haze had already been “depraved,” using casual misogyny to justify his actions. His persistent insistence that he is “not concerned with so-called “sex” at all” reveals a deliberate rhetorical sleight-of-hand. By taking away the power of the language that has the possibility of unmasking him, he obscures the reality of his actions. Humbert hides behind internal mediation; he cannot openly acknowledge the mediator (the taboo figure of the adolescent “nymphet”) or his own illicit mimetic desire, so he reduces the crime to an imagined seduction by Lolita and relieves himself of culpability.

On the other hand, when we consider Humbert’s desire towards the symbol of the nymphet, we see the power of external mediation. Here, the mediator becomes the broader cultural fetishizing of girlish youth. This desire is thus articulated with the boldness of external mediation. His outline of the criteria for a nymphet first becomes a means of framing himself as a scholar, but also serves to align Humbert’s desire with the broader public opinion. His overt proclamation casts his desire as not merely personal but as part of a societal convention of aesthetic appreciation, legitimating it in the reader’s eyes. More importantly, it allows him to invite the reader to imitate him. While acknowledging the external mediation acting upon him by society, Humbert also puts himself in the mediator’s position, and tries to manipulate the reader into sharing his desire of nymphets. To do so, he turns his text into a vessel for mimetic desire. This creates a self-enforcing cycle where the more openly he speaks of the nymphet ideal, the more he rationalizes the subjugation of Haze to fit that image. This becomes, as he admits, Humbert’s “greater endeavor,” which is “to fix once for all the perilous magic of nymphets” (Nabokov, 134).

Egeus similarly exhibits both internal and external mediations acting upon his desires. In both cases, Egeus's desire is not for Berenice herself, but rather her teeth and what they symbolize. Although he uses his façade as a dispassionate scholar to reject any admiration and desire towards Berenice, it is clear his goal is not to merely “analyze” her. His description of her teeth is reminiscent of Humbert's description of nymphets:

But from the disordered chamber of my brain, had not, alas! departed, and would not be driven away, the white and ghastly *spectrum* of the teeth. Not a speck on their surface – not a shade on their enamel – not an indenture in their edges – but what that period of her smile had sufficed to brand in upon my memory. I saw them *now* even more unequivocally than I beheld them *then*. The teeth! – the teeth! – they were here, and there, and everywhere, and visibly and palpably before me; long, narrow, and excessively white, with the pale lips writhing about them, as in the very moment of their first terrible development. [...] All other matters and all different interests became absorbed in their single contemplation. They – they alone were present to the mental eye, and they, in their sole individuality, became the essence of my mental life. I held them in every light. I turned them in every attitude. I surveyed their characteristics. I dwelt upon their peculiarities. I pondered upon their conformation. I mused upon the alteration in their nature. I shuddered as I assigned to them in imagination a sensitive and sentient power, and even when unassisted by the lips, a capability of moral expression. Of Mademoiselle Sallé it has been well said, “*Que tous ses pas étaient des sentiments*,” (her every step was a sentiment) and of Berenice I more seriously believed *que toutes ses dents étaient des idées. Des idées!* (that all her teeth were ideas. Ideas!) – ah, here was the idiotic thought that destroyed me! *Des idées!* – ah *therefore* it was that I coveted them so madly! I felt that their possession could alone ever restore me to peace, in giving me back to reason.

Poe, “Berenice”

His obsessive description of Berenice's “white and ghastly spectrum of [...] teeth” as “ideas” is an attempt to fix his desire in a guise of scientific inquiry. Just as he positions himself as an

intellectual through his justification of his madness as an academic pursuit, Egaeus similarly rationalizes his obsession over Berenice's teeth. After he "turned them in every attitude," "surveyed their characteristics," "dwelt upon their peculiarities," and "pondered upon their conformation," Egaeus convinces himself and attempts to convince the reader that "*que toutes ses dents étaient des idées* (all her teeth were ideas)," and gives this as a reason why "[he] coveted them so madly," as their possession would give him "back to reason."

The external mediator in this case is the academic inquiry that Egaeus claims to pursue. Just as "the hero of external mediation proclaims aloud the true nature of his desire" (Hale, 299), Egaeus clearly delineates his worship of scientific discourse and aesthetic classification. This external mediation is also used by Egaeus to legitimize his desire for Berenice's teeth. However, the internal mediation of Egaeus's desire is the idea of complete control and purity. Egaeus attempts to conceal the effect this mediation has on himself, describing his passions as "always of the mind." In claiming this, he separates himself from desires of the heart, but this attempt only heightens his connection to the internal mediator. Girard states that even as the subject "thinks only of repudiating the bonds of mediation, [...] these bonds are stronger than ever, for the mediator's apparent hostility does not diminish his prestige but instead augments it" (Hale, 299). Thus, the more Egaeus tries to write himself as a dispassionate scholar devoid of influence, his private obsession with teeth (the embodiment of perfect order and purity) increasingly governs his thoughts. This hidden mediation thus compels him to endow a certain spiritual significance to the teeth: "*que toutes ses dents étaient des idées*." By hiding this internal mediator behind a façade of rational inquiry, Egaeus not only deceives himself but also invites the reader into his mimetic loop, leading both narrator and the readers to the final act of violence.

Girard's framework of triangular desire carries significant ethical weight in the context of these two texts. The external mediator for both is the cultural fixation on purity and youth rather than any specific individuals. This shift compels us to reconsider the roles of Egaeus and Humbert Humbert, from isolated villains to products of a broader collective complicity. While this in no way mitigates their crimes, their narrative voices reflect and reinforce society's more troubling notions of justice and morality. Just as Egaeus frames himself as an academic by confounding Berenice's teeth with "ideas," Humbert Humbert also implicitly requests the reader to overlook his crimes by appealing to his own mastery of language. Perhaps the craftiest way he does so is by creating a framework in the narrative that mirrors a legal trial: Humbert manipulates the reader by insinuating that they have merely a binary choice: to condemn him as guilty or innocent. After creating this structure, he uses not only his intellect (similar to Egaeus) but constantly exhibits his admiration of aesthetic pleasure through his beautiful prose in order to convince the reader to take on a stance similar to that of 'Vladimir Nabokov' at the afterword of *Lolita*:

Lolita has no moral in tow. For me a work of fiction exists only insofar as it affords me what I shall bluntly call aesthetic bliss, that is a sense of being somehow, somewhere, connected with other states of being where art (curiosity, tenderness, kindness, ecstasy) is the norm. There are not many such books. All the rest is either topical trash coming in huge blocks of plaster that are carefully transmitted from age to age until somebody comes along with a hammer and takes a good crack at Balzac, at Gorki, at Mann.

Vladimir Nabokov, On a Book Entitled Lolita

I use quotation marks for Nabokov's name in this setting due to the opinion that this is not truly the sentiment of Vladimir Nabokov, but rather yet another character that Nabokov has created,

much like John Ray, the fictional character who writes the foreword and adopts quite the opposite stance from ‘Vladimir Nabokov’:

As a case history, “Lolita” will become, no doubt, a classic in psychiatric circles. As a work of art, it transcends its expiatory aspects; and still more important to us than scientific significance and literary worth, is the ethical impact the book should have on the serious reader; [...] [it warns] us of dangerous trends; [it points] out potent evils. “Lolita” should make all of us – parents, social workers, educators – apply ourselves with still greater vigilance and vision to the task of bringing up a better generation in a safer world.

John Ray, Foreword

While it seems as though John Ray acknowledges and advises measures against Humbert Humbert’s crimes, there is no mention of the culpability of our society apart from implicit advice to parents to keep better watch of their children. Further, when Ray talks about applying “ourselves with still greater vigilance and vision,” he is primarily concerned with being vigilant about children, while, as Girard helps to point out, the primary subject of vigilance should be society’s unnamed desire and fetishization of youth and girlhood.

Thus, the foreword and afterword of *Lolita* give us the two ways Humbert Humbert limits us into thinking about the novel, forcing us to see *Lolita* either as a simple warning against pedophiles or purely as a work of art. However, a sinister ethical danger lurks in deciding to concede to Humbert’s binary choice. In doing so, the reader takes away any personhood of Dolores Haze while ignoring any appreciation of Humbert’s language. The moral implications of *Lolita* lie in holding the two integral parts of the novel together in uncomfortable tension, where aesthetic pleasure neither exonerates nor becomes diminished by the horrific crimes of Humbert. Only by seeing both aspects of the novel *Lolita* can the reader begin to understand and perceive

the omniscient mediator that is the life source of Humbert's desire, which is society's own desire for Dolores Haze, Annabel Leigh, and other so-called nymphets.

In answering our original question about the ethical ramifications of *Lolita*, we as readers must realize that we are caught in a juxtaposition between "aesthetic bliss," where "art [...] is the norm" (Nabokov) and the moral horrors of Humbert Humbert and Egaeus's actions. This irony is complex but it is also the very focus of the narrative engines we have analyzed thus far. This, however, mostly applies to *Lolita*; In 'Berenice,' as Egaeus meets literary doom, Poe takes away the necessity to hold the two forces of aesthetics and moral recoil together. Still, the gothic short story is critical in our evaluation of Humbert Humbert, as Egaeus performs many of the similar narrative tactics used by the former, albeit in a much more obvious form. The divergence of the two texts lends itself to the realization that the enjoyment of the narrative is undermined by the discomfort of the narrators and commands us to see our own complicity in the forces that drive the narratives. If we conclude that this discomfort is worth eliminating these narratives altogether, we wind up in a loop where we have to have read the narrative to make this decision, thus contradicting the statement. Rather, these texts demand that we sit with our discomfort, to see how the seductive power of language can enlist us as imitators of the narrator's gaze, and to refuse that role.

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